more-than-150 annual reports of companies to understand how Ratan transformed the seven larger enterprises as the head of the group for over twenty-one years. But laying hands on these was an arduous task.

Information on Tata companies from a time when reports were not digitized was hard to come by. And the Tata companies have not earned a name as the best of record keepers. In many cases, the source of last resort was surprisingly the much-vilified government, whose record-keeping methods saved the day.

A friend in the ministry of corporate affairs, for instance, unearthed the holdings of the Birla group in TISCO (now Tata Steel) in less than seventy hours. The information was critical as the outside group had had more shares in the group's flagship company than Tata Sons did, when Ratan took over the group.

Information on the market cap and share price movements of Tata companies were also unavailable with the individual companies, and the friends I had made in my tenure in the department of economic affairs as the joint secretary (capital market) and as a SEBI board member, helped in no small measure. A stock exchange deployed some of its staff for many months to manually aggregate information that was only stored in bound records as they related to the early 1990s when digitization was a rarity.

To make things more difficult, many documents that could throw light on the enormity of changes that Ratan brought about in the Tata companies and in Tata Sons were untraceable or lost, compelling me to reach out to famed Tata veterans for clues. But many of them were long retired. Yet they spent hours with me, sharing information on the epochal era of Ratan that would have been lost to history, but for my interaction with them. To them, I owe my sincerest gratitude. Some of them have since passed on: J.J. Irani, F.C. Kohli, Syamal Gupta, R.K. Krishna Kumar and K.P. Mahalingam are among them.

And those outside the group I spent considerable time discussing Ratan included the doyen of international politics, Henry Kissinger, and some of Ratan's Cornell colleagues—the most notable being Phil Handler, who had done extensive research on Ratan for the Cornell programme called 'Ratan Tata '59: The Cornell Story'. Though Phil lived in Connecticut, he stayed in New York where I was for as many days as I desired, spending almost all his waking hours with me, talking about Ratan's life in the university and